Pre-Implementation Ethics Checklist for AI-Generated Case Videos

Review all 11 items before using an AI-generated avatar case video in class. The items correspond to Table 2 of the accompanying article and address client integrity, student safety, transparency, legal and ethical preparedness, debrief, and student conscience.

Client integrity

- [ ] 1. **Fictional composite.** Is the client a purely fictional composite, not based on any identifiable real person's story or specific life details, with any real person's likeness or voice (e.g., a stock avatar modeled on an actor) used only with that person's consent?
- [ ] 2. **Avoid stereotypes.** Does the demographic profile and case narrative serve a clear learning objective rather than relying on or reinforcing stereotypes?

Student safety

- [ ] 3. **Calibrated distress.** Is the level of trauma detail or emotional intensity proportionate to the learning objectives?
- [ ] 4. **Content warning included.** Does the assignment include a clear content warning for students with relevant personal histories (e.g., military, trauma, addiction, immigration)?

Transparency

- [ ] 5. **AI tool disclosed.** Have you explicitly disclosed that the case was generated with AI (including naming the tool, e.g., HeyGen) and its limitations?
- [ ] 6. **Student acknowledgment.** Have students been informed that the case is AI-generated and given an opportunity to acknowledge the exercise?

Legal and ethical preparedness

- [ ] 7. **Mandatory reporting reviewed.** Have you identified mandatory reporting, confidentiality limits, or legal issues and prepared instructor guidance?
- [ ] 8. **Competence and accuracy review.** Have you personally reviewed the video and transcript for clinical accuracy, cultural appropriateness, and social work values?
- [ ] 9. **Anti-oppressive and bias check.** Has the case been reviewed to minimize bias or oppressive portrayals in avatar design and scenario?

Debrief

- [ ] 10. **Space to process.** Does the lesson plan include structured debrief time and resources for students if the case activates personal material?

Student conscience

- [ ] 11. **Alternative pathway.** Is an equivalent non-AI pathway to the same learning objective (e.g., the same composite case as a written vignette or live role-play) available, without penalty, for students who decline AI-mediated material on conscience grounds?

Suggested citation. Schuman, D. L., & Bartlett, T. (2026). AI avatars in social work education: Case-based teaching and ethics guidance [Companion web resource]. https://ai-avatars-in-socialwork.netlify.app/

Donna L. Schuman, PhD, LCSW, Associate Professor, School of Social Work, The University of Texas at Arlington, and Tanya Bartlett, LCSW. Licensed CC BY-NC 4.0. Last updated September 2026.